FIELD STATION

Written by

the Method Reader project

Placeholder Pictures
hello@example.com

EXT. RIDGE ROAD - DAY

Wind comes down off the ridge in long flat gusts, pushing the grass one way and then, for no reason, the other.

A road climbs the ridge in switchbacks. Nobody has driven it since the washout, and the grass is taking it back.

MARA, 40s, walks it with a pack on and four days in her legs. She has the face of someone who fixes things and is never thanked.

DELACROIX, 50s, walks behind her with a paper map folded to the right square. He does not look at it. He looks at the road, and counts.

DELACROIX
Thirty-one.

They take the bend. Gravel lets go under Mara’s boot and goes quietly over the edge.

MARA
You don’t have to do that out loud.

DELACROIX
The map says forty. I’d like to know when it’s lying.

Cloud sits on the ridge above them like a lid somebody forgot to close.

MARA
How long has he been up there?

DELACROIX
Three weeks. On his own.

MARA
They said two.

DELACROIX
They say a lot of things.

The road ends at the washout, a bite taken out of the mountain. Mara stops where the road stops, then goes round it on the rock.

DELACROIX
Thirty-eight.

EXT. FIELD STATION - DAY

MARA and DELACROIX come up the last of the slope, packs on, bent into the wind. Below them the road they walked is a thin grey line, going all the way down.

The station: a prefab hut bolted to the rock, a radio mast guyed four ways, a fuel drum, a generator crouched under a tarp. Everything that can rattle, rattles.

The hut door opens before they reach it.

TEO, 20s, comes out in two jumpers and no coat. Thin. He has the look of someone who has rehearsed what to say to people and forgotten all of it.

TEO
You came.

DELACROIX
We said we would.

TEO
People say that on the radio. It’s different, seeing it.

He shakes Delacroix’s hand, then Mara’s, then Delacroix’s again.

MARA
You’re Teo.

TEO
I’m Teo. Sorry. Come in, it’s warmer. It isn’t, but it’s out of the wind.

The wind leans on all three of them. The mast answers it with a low note, like someone humming through their teeth.

TEO (CONT’D)
That’s the mast. You get used to it.

MARA
Do you?

TEO
No.

Teo walks them round the station at a pace that makes it hard to see any of it.

TEO
Fuel. Water. Rain gauge. It’s been fine the whole time.

He points up at the mast without looking at it.

TEO (CONT’D)
It sings in a north wind. One long note. In a west wind it’s two, and they don’t agree.

DELACROIX
And an east wind?

TEO
We don’t get an east wind.

He thinks about it.

TEO (CONT’D)
We got one once.

Mara crouches by the generator and lifts the tarp. Oil on the housing, old and new. One bolt is missing. Another turns in her fingers with no thread left to hold it.

She looks at it for a long moment. Then she lets the tarp fall.

DELACROIX
Well?

MARA
It runs.

That is all she says. Delacroix has worked with her long enough to count what she leaves out.

TEO
I kept it running. Every day. I wrote it down.

MARA
I believe you.

Teo nods too many times and goes inside. The wind shuts the door behind him, hard.

INT. FIELD STATION - DAY

One room. A cot, a table, one chair. A tarp lashed over a gap in the north wall where a panel used to be. It breathes with the weather.

On the wall above the radio, a map of the valley. Four pins in it, running down the line to the lowest station.

DELACROIX
(into the handset)
Base, this is Field Station. We’re up.

Static. Then a voice, patient, a long way off.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Field Station, Iversen. Good to hear you. How’s the boy?

Delacroix glances at Teo, who is shelving their tins in order of size.

DELACROIX
Tidy.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Pickup is tomorrow, first light. Relief team brings the new keeper up and the three of you down.

DELACROIX
First light.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Weather permitting. It always permits, until it doesn’t.

He sets the handset down. Mara is looking at the map.

MARA
Why four pins?

TEO
One for every station on the line. We’re the top one.

He touches the lowest pin, then takes his finger away as if it were warm.

EXT. RADIO MAST - DUSK

The light goes early up here. What is left of it is the colour of weak tea.

MARA climbs the mast, harness clipped to the ladder, a spanner through her belt. The wind pulls at her like it wants her for something.

DELACROIX stands at the foot, the safety line paid out through his gloves.

DELACROIX
How many rungs?

MARA
I don’t count them.

DELACROIX
Forty-four. I counted for you.

She reaches the antenna. It hangs off true, its bracket worked loose by a winter of north wind.

DELACROIX
Can I ask you something?

MARA
You’re going to.

DELACROIX
Why did you take this job? You could fix things anywhere. Somewhere with walls.

A gust takes the mast and leans it an inch. She waits it out, cheek against the cold steel, eyes shut.

Below her, the line goes taut in his hands and stays taut until the gust is gone.

MARA
Nothing up here pretends to work.

Delacroix thinks about that. Decides not to agree with it out loud.

She sets the spanner to the bracket. Two turns. The antenna comes true, and the mast’s low note changes pitch, very slightly, as if it has noticed.

DELACROIX
Is that it?

MARA
That’s it.

She doesn’t come down. She is looking past him, past the hut, out across the valley to the far ridge.

A light. One small steady point of it, low on the far slope, where the map shows nothing at all.

It does not flicker. Nothing out there has any reason to be lit.

DELACROIX
Mara? You’re losing the light.

The point goes out, like somebody closing a hand around it.

MARA
Coming down.

She unclips and starts down, rung by rung. She does not mention it. She will not mention it for some time.

INT. FIELD STATION - EVENING

Three of them round a table built for one. Tins on a camping stove. The tarp on the north wall breathes in, out.

TEO eats fast, like the food might be taken back.

DELACROIX
Four pins. Tell me about them.

TEO
We call down the line at six every evening. Everybody answers. We all say goodnight.

MARA
Everybody?

Teo puts his fork down.

TEO
The fourth hasn’t answered. Nine days.

A pause. The stove ticks as it cools.

DELACROIX
Nine days, and you didn’t report it.

TEO
I did. Every night, after I called them, I reported it to base.

DELACROIX
And?

TEO
Nobody answered that either.

Delacroix looks at Mara. Mara looks at the radio. The radio hisses and says nothing, the way it has said nothing for nine days.

MARA
Iversen answered today.

TEO
Iversen answered you.

EXT. RIDGE - NIGHT

Wind, and under the wind a cold that means business.

DELACROIX walks the ridge with a torch, the beam no use against anything further off than his own boots.

He finds the marker cairn where the map says it will be: a chest-high stack of flat stones, sighted down the valley toward the fourth station. In clear weather you could see its lamp from here.

There is no lamp tonight. There is no clear weather.

He sets the torch on the ground and looks at the cairn properly.

It has been rebuilt. Carefully. Every stone seated, every gap chinked with smaller stones. Nobody did this in a hurry, and nobody did it for the weather.

DELACROIX
Hello?

The wind takes the word and does not bring it back.

He knows this cairn. He built the last one himself, eleven years ago, and he knows how many stones went into it. Twenty-six.

He counts them. His lips move.

DELACROIX
Twenty-five.

He counts again, slower, touching each one with a gloved finger, top to bottom.

DELACROIX (CONT’D)
Twenty-five.

One short. Whoever rebuilt it built it well and built it one stone short, and a careful person does not make that mistake by accident.

He sweeps the torch around his feet. Grass. Rock. No stone lying loose.

Down in the valley, where the fourth station should be, there is only dark.

He switches the torch off and stands in it for a moment, to see what his eyes will do.

Nothing out there changes. Nothing out there has changed for nine days.

He turns the torch back on and walks back toward the hut, faster than he came.

INT. FIELD STATION - LATER

Mara is asleep on the cot in her boots. Teo is not asleep, and not pretending to be.

The radio crackles. Delacroix comes in with the cold still on him and goes straight to the handset.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Field Station, Iversen. Field Station, do you read?

DELACROIX
Go ahead.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Weather’s closing over the pass. Relief is delayed.

DELACROIX
Delayed how long?

Static, for long enough that Teo sits up.

IVERSEN (V.O.)
Twenty-three hours, earliest. We’ll hold here until it...

The hiss closes over the rest.

DELACROIX
Iversen. Come back.

Nothing. Delacroix sets the handset down gently, as if it might still be listening.

He takes a pencil from his pocket and writes 23 on the wall beside the map, small and neat. He looks at it. Underlines it.

TEO
Was that him? Was that really him?

DELACROIX
Go to sleep, Teo.

EXT. FIELD STATION - NIGHT

The wind has found a new direction and does not like that one either.

TEO wheels the quad bike out of the lean-to. Headlamp on. A jerrycan strapped across the back, and a second map, the survey copy, rolled under his arm.

MARA comes out after him, pulling on her coat.

MARA
Teo.

TEO
It’s four hours down if the track’s clear. I’ll see them. I’ll come back and tell you.

MARA
Don’t.

TEO
Nine days. Somebody has to go and look.

MARA
In the morning. With us.

TEO
In the morning there’ll be a reason to wait until the afternoon.

He is not wrong, and she knows it, and that is the worst part.

MARA
Call us when you get there.

TEO
I always call.

He kicks the bike over. It catches first time, which feels like a verdict.

DELACROIX is in the doorway now, the lamp behind him.

DELACROIX
Four hours down. Four back. The relief is twenty-three.

TEO
Then I’ll be back before them.

Teo pulls out onto the track. The headlamp swings across the rock, across the fuel drum, and settles on the way down.

They watch the tail light go. Red, small, smaller. It dips below the lip of the ridge, comes up once more on the next switchback, and then does not come up again.

Mara keeps looking at the place where it was.

DELACROIX
You could have stopped him.

MARA
I could have slowed him down.

Behind them, under its tarp, the generator coughs.

Once. A dry, small sound, like someone clearing their throat before bad news. Then it runs on, even and ordinary, as if nothing happened.

Neither of them says anything. Delacroix looks at his watch and does not say the time.

CUT TO:

EXT. LOWER STATION - NIGHT

A hut like theirs, lower and older, in a fold of the valley where the wind cannot quite reach and so sulks instead.

A headlamp comes down the track and stops. TEO kills the engine. The silence is enormous.

The door of the hut is open. Not blown open. Propped, with a stone.

TEO
Hello? It’s Teo. From the top.

Nothing. He goes in.

Inside, the station is neat. The cot is made. A mug stands on the table with a skin on its cold tea.

The radio is on. Its dial glows a soft green, the only light in the room.

Teo leans in to read the frequency. He knows the number. It is theirs.

Beside the radio a notebook lies open. Line after line of the same entry, in a hand that gets smaller down the page. Six o’clock. Six o’clock. Six o’clock.

Someone has been listening. Every night. And never once said a word.

Teo picks up the handset. His thumb finds the key.

He holds it down.

INT. FIELD STATION - NIGHT

The generator coughs once and dies. MARA works by the light of her phone, hands steady, and does not look up.

MARA
Give it a minute. It always comes back.

DELACROIX
And if it doesn’t?

She finds the housing bolt by feel. Turns it a quarter turn.

MARA
Then we do this in the dark.

The wind takes the tarp on the north wall and holds it open like a door nobody opened.

DELACROIX
That’s not an answer.

MARA
It’s the one I have.

He crosses to the window. Outside, the ridge is a black line against a slightly less black sky.

DELACROIX
Nineteen hours until the relief team. I counted.

MARA
Then stop counting.

The generator catches. Dies again. Catches.

Light comes up amber and unsteady, and the room assembles itself around them: the cot, the radio, the map with its four pins.

MARA (CONT’D)
There. Told you.

DELACROIX
You told me a minute. That was six.

MARA
I rounded.

She wipes her hands on her thigh and sits, finally, like the sitting costs her something.

DELACROIX
You should sleep.

MARA
You should stop saying that.

A long moment. The radio hisses, says nothing, hisses.

DELACROIX
If the relief doesn’t come.

MARA
They’ll come.

DELACROIX
If.

MARA
Then we walk out the way we walked in, and it takes four days instead of one, and you complain the entire time.

DELACROIX
I don’t complain.

MARA
You’re complaining now.

He almost laughs. It is the first honest sound either of them has made all night.

DELACROIX
Get some sleep. I’ll take the radio.

She doesn’t argue, which frightens him more than the dark did.

CUT TO:

INT. FIELD STATION - DAWN

Grey light. The tarp is down. The map is gone from the wall.

DELACROIX sits exactly where he sat, the handset still in his fist, asleep with his eyes open the way soldiers learn.

The radio speaks. One word, clipped, in a voice neither of them has heard.

He is awake before he knows he is awake.

DELACROIX
Say again.

Nothing. The hiss closes over the word like water.

DELACROIX (CONT’D)
Say again.

He turns the dial one notch, then back, then one notch the other way, hunting the frequency the way you hunt a name you have almost remembered.

MARA (O.S.)
What was it?

She is in the doorway. She has not slept and does not pretend otherwise.

DELACROIX
A voice. One word. I couldn’t hold it.

MARA
Which word?

He looks at the handset, then at her.

DELACROIX
Ours.

Outside, very far off, something that is not the wind moves along the ridge.

FADE OUT.